

Tsuemi-hime and the Seven Forest Spirits

A Fairytale of Mitsue Valley

Prologue: The Ancient Gift

Long, long ago — so long ago that the mountains were still young and the fireflies of Mitsue were as bright as small suns — a great princess walked through the valleys of Yamato.

Her name was **Yamatohime-no-Mikoto**, daughter of heaven, and she was on the most sacred of errands: to find a perfect home for Amaterasu, the Sun Goddess herself. She crossed rivers, climbed forested ridgelines, and prayed at every spring. When at last she descended into a valley ringed by mountains where the mist gathered like sleeping clouds, she felt it: the hum in her chest that meant *here is something holy*.

She left her staff planted in the earth at the valley's heart — not because she was tired, but because a staff, when blessed and left with intention, becomes a promise. Then she walked on toward the sea, to find Ise, and to complete her journey.

The valley kept the staff. The valley kept the promise. And from that day the place was called 御杖 — *Mitsue* — "the honorable staff."

Part One: The Kingdom Asleep

Many centuries later, in that same valley, there lived a young woman known to all as **Tsuemi-hime**.

She was not a princess in the way of palaces and crowns. She was a princess of the mountain kind: quick-footed on mossy trails, able to read weather in the flight of bush-warblers, and possessed of a peculiar wand-shaped lock of hair that she had worn since childhood — a mark, the old grandmothers said, of Yamatohime's blessing on the valley. The village mascot had always looked just like her, right down to that spiraled lock and the slender staff she carried.

Mitsue was a beautiful village. Mountain cherry blossoms in spring, fireflies dancing at Maruyama Park in summer, red leaves blazing in autumn, rime ice on the peaks in winter. The Kushida River ran clear. The old shrine at the top of the hill sheltered Yamatohime's sacred memory.

But something had gone deeply wrong.

Year by year, the young people had left for the cities. Schools had closed. Fields had fallen idle. And worst of all — the forests had changed.

In the high places where ancient broadleaf oaks and maples had once stood, giving way to chestnuts, kaya nut trees, and wildflowers, a different tree now reigned without challenge: the **sugi**. Row after endless row of plantation cedar, planted decades ago by well-meaning hands, now stood in silent columns, blocking the light, strangling the soil, dropping their pollen in clouds that made the remaining villagers sneeze and weep each spring. Bears, confused and hungry because the nut-bearing trees were gone, wandered down into the village. Birds fell silent. The undergrowth vanished.

And at the center of this grey-green monoculture, where no one had walked in years, lived a presence the woodcutters whispered about: **the Sugi Witch**.

Part Two: The Sugi Witch's Mirror

The Sugi Witch did not look like a witch. She looked like a spreadsheet.

She was the spirit of short-term economics: of planting one profitable tree in every direction and calling it a forest, of closing the school because the enrollment numbers fell, of letting the roads deteriorate because fixing them cost more than the shrinking tax base could bear. She lived in the dark between the endless cedar trunks, and her mirror was a screen that showed her nothing but statistics.

Each morning she consulted it.

*"Mirror, mirror, cold and bright,
which Japanese village shall never rise? Which shall never see the light?"*

And the mirror answered: *Mitsue. Mitsue. Population 1,393 and falling. School closed. Young people: gone.*

The Witch smiled with the satisfaction of inevitability.

But one spring morning, the mirror flickered. An anomaly. Something was moving in the valley that had no place in her numbers.

Part Three: The Wanderer from the Sea

There had come to Mitsue a man from very far away — from a distant northern country of windmills and flat lands, though he had lived in Japan for so long that he knew its mountains better than most. He had arrived on the shore of Japan as a young man, been shaped by the radiation-counting work of citizen scientists after the great disaster at Fukushima, and spent decades building small devices that measured invisible things: small boards with circuit traces fine as spider-thread, sensors that could feel what human senses could not.

His name was **Rob**, and he had come to Mitsue not to visit but to *stay* — on a floating house on a mountain stream, surrounded by sugi pollen every spring and fireflies every summer. He had watched the valley for years before he spoke. And when he finally spoke, it was to Tsuemi-hime.

"Your valley is not dying," he said. "It is sleeping under a spell. And I think I know how to break it — but I cannot do it alone."

Tsuemi-hime regarded him with the calm eyes of someone who had heard many promises. She tapped her staff on the ground once. "Then we will look for help," she said.

And together they walked up into the forest, to find the Seven.

Part Four: The Seven Forest Spirits

Deep in the mountains, where the sugi plantation thinned and a few old broadleaf trees still remembered what the forest had once been, seven small spirits lived and worked.

They were not tall. They were not glamorous. But they were each the guardian of one piece of what the valley needed.

The first was **Mori** — the Forest Keeper.

He was the oldest and the quietest. He spent his days planting acorns and kaya nuts, reading soil maps, and arguing with the plantation owners about letting light back in. He wore a hat made of dried oak leaves and kept detailed records of every native tree still standing. He would tell you, if you sat with him long enough, that sugi was not evil — it was simply *placed wrong*, and that a managed harvest, conducted patiently, could convert the plantation into a resource and the clearings into a future. But patience, he said. Twenty-five years, minimum. "Ecological restoration," he muttered, "is not a sprint."

The second was **Bio** — the Heat-Keeper.

She was small and stout and always warm to the touch, because she was the spirit of biomass energy: the knowledge that the wood that comes out of a responsibly harvested forest is not waste but fuel. She tended a biomass boiler no bigger than a garden shed and kept its flame going through the coldest winters, heating the old school building until its plaster walls steamed gently in the mountain air. She was careful to say: *heat first, electricity second*. "A boiler costs a third of a combined heat-and-power unit," she would say cheerfully, "and wastes almost nothing." She smelled permanently of cedar smoke.

The third was **Tane** — the Seed Planter.

He was the youngest and the most patient, which was unusual. Most young spirits are restless; Tane had understood early that restoration moved at the pace of trees, not of people. He collected seeds — kaya nuts, mountain cherry pits, the fruit of konara oaks — and kept them in careful rows of small pots outside his door. He said almost nothing, but when he did speak it was usually some variation of: "In twenty-five years, this will be a broadleaf forest again." He had the look of someone who genuinely believed this.

The fourth was **Deta** — the Data Keeper.

She was the most peculiar of the seven, because she lived not in the forest at all but in the old elementary school building, surrounded by humming machines and soft blue lights. She had moved in after the school closed, because she said the building was too beautiful to abandon and too useful to leave dark. The machines she tended were small, efficient, and powered by Bio's boiler heat and the solar panels on the roof — they did computation, she explained: AI inference, edge processing, cloud services for the region. She was building something the valley had never had: digital infrastructure that belonged to the community, run on local energy, open to any resident who needed it.

"A data center doesn't have to be a hyperscale monster," she said, when the Sugi Witch's mirror sent a scornful number her way. "It just has to be *here*, and *ours*, and *on*."

The fifth was **Denki** — the Spark-Maker.

He was quick and a little restless, always in motion. He managed the EV charging stations that Bio's energy fed, humming to himself as he checked connections and logged the arrival of electric vehicles at each station. He had a vision: that within a decade, all the kei-trucks and farm vehicles and forestry machines in Mitsue would run on electricity generated in Mitsue. "Energy sovereignty," he called it. The others called it *Denki's dream* and smiled — but they did not disagree.

The sixth was **Akari** — the Light-Sharer.

She was the storyteller of the seven. Everything the others did, she wrote down: the species counts, the boiler temperatures, the server uptime numbers, the meeting notes from conversations with the village mayor. She published it all under open licences, because she believed — with a conviction that sometimes alarmed the others — that if Mitsue could do this, any village could do this, and every village should know how. "Documentation," she said firmly, "is a deliverable. Not an afterthought."

The seventh was **Gate** — the Funding Guardian.

Gate was the most feared and the most necessary. He stood at the door between each phase of the work and the next, and he would not let anyone through until the funding was secured and the accounts were checked. He was not unkind, but he was implacable. He had seen too many good projects run into the next phase on hope and momentum alone, and collapse. "Phase 1 does not begin," he said at every planning meeting, "until Gate 1 is cleared. Three to eight million yen, confirmed." The others sometimes resented him. They always thanked him later.

Part Five: Two Sages at the Edge of the Wood

Before Tsuemi-hime and Rob could begin, they needed the wisdom of those who had seen the wider world.

They traveled — not by foot, but by message and by trust — to seek two great sages who had agreed to lend their counsel.

The first was **Joi**, who had once kept the world's most famous library of new ideas, at a great institute by the sea in the distant East, and who understood better than almost anyone how technology could be made to serve the human rather than consume it.

The second was **Ray**, who had built invisible architectures that millions of people used without knowing — great systems that breathed beneath the surface of the digital world — and who had since turned his thoughts to what those systems could do for the small and the overlooked.

Both sages had said yes. Both sages were on the map.

"Good," said Gate, checking his ledger. "Advisory commitments confirmed. Phase 0 may proceed."

Part Six: The Poisoned School

The Sugi Witch, watching from her mirror, grew afraid.

Afraid is not quite the right word. What she felt was more like a number going the wrong way. Her certainty — built on decades of statistics — had developed a crack. She needed to stop this.

She knew the project's heart: the old school building, standing empty at the center of the village. It was the keystone. Without it, there was no data center, no hub, no replicable model. Just a collection of earnest people standing in a cedar forest.

So she cast her oldest spell on the school: the spell of **accumulated neglect** — the slow poison of a building that has been closed for long enough that no one believes it can be opened again. Maintenance costs. Asbestos inspections. Permits. Insurance. The accumulated weight of institutional hesitation.

When Tsuemi-hime and Rob came to the school on a grey morning in early spring, they found the door swollen in its frame. The windows were filmed with years of mountain grime. Inside, the light switches did nothing.

Tsuemi-hime pressed her hand against the school's cold wall and felt, faintly, the warmth of children who had once run these corridors.

"It is not dead," she said. "It is waiting."

Rob pulled out his notebook and began to write.

Part Seven: The Breaking of the Spell

The breaking of the spell took not a kiss but a stamp — the red stamp of the Legal Affairs Bureau in Nara City, acknowledging the founding of the 一般社団法人御杖プロジェクト — the Mitsue Project General Incorporated Association.

There were two founding members. Rob. And **Yuka**, his partner and co-founder, who had seen from the beginning what the valley could become, and whose name went on the charter beside his as proof that this was not one person's dream but a shared one.

When the stamp came down, something shifted in the cedar forest.

Mori heard it first: a thinning of the spell in the soil, a loosening. He planted three more oaks.

Bio felt it in her boiler: a steadier flame. She calculated the heat output and smiled.

Deta powered on the first server in the old school's main hall. The blue light filled the dusty corridor like the beginning of a dawn.

Gate opened his ledger to a new page.

And in the heart of the valley, at Mitsue Shrine, where Yamatohime had left her staff two thousand years ago, the cherry blossoms opened early — ten days before the forecast, which no one could explain, but everyone accepted.

Part Eight: The Long Work

The witch was not gone. Spells as old as economic neglect do not break in a single stamp.

There were setbacks. A funding gate that did not clear on the first attempt. A forestry cooperative that needed months of patient conversation before it trusted. A mayor who listened and nodded and asked the question all mayors ask: *"And if it fails?"*

"Then we will have planted trees, trained people, documented what we learned, and left the school better than we found it," said Tsuemi-hime. "That is not failure. That is Phase 0."

The mayor looked at her for a long time. Then he nodded more slowly.

Akari wrote it all down.

Epilogue: Twenty-Five Years Later

Come with me now into the future. Not far — just twenty-five years.

Stand at the ridge above Mitsue in late October.

The cedar rows are gone from the south-facing slopes: in their place, a patchwork of young oaks, maples, kaya nut trees, and mountain cherry, with selective stands of timber cedar managed on a rotation that gives the forestry cooperative income without ever stripping the land bare. The bears have stopped coming down into the village because they have enough to eat in the forest again. The pollen count in spring is a fraction of what it was.

Below, at the old school, the lights are on. The building has been carefully renovated — insulated, weatherproofed, its old wood floors polished — and it hums with servers that run on electricity generated by the biomass boiler in the building next door, by the solar panels on the roof, by the micro-hydro turbine on the Kushida River. The data center is small. It is not trying to be Amazon. It is trying to be *Mitsue's* — and it is. The village owns it. The village benefits from it. Seven other villages in Nara and Mie prefectures have now built their own versions, using Akari's openly published documentation.

The EV charging stations dot the valley road, quiet and busy.

At the roadside station, you can still buy a staff-shaped churro in honor of Tsuemi-chan, the village mascot — the little figure with the wand-like curl of hair, the nod to Yamatohime's ancient promise.

And at Mitsue Shrine, when the autumn festival comes, the men carry the great taikodai through the grounds, and their voices echo off the mountain slopes, and somewhere in the crowd a child asks her grandmother: "Why is the village called Mitsue?"

And the grandmother says: "Because a princess left her staff here, and the valley kept the promise."

And they all lived long, slowly, and open-source forever after.

— Based on the repository at codeberg.org/YR-Design/mitsue-ai-data-center and the legend of Yamatohime-no-Mikoto

The Seven Forest Spirits correspond to the seven operating principles and programme components of the Mitsue Project: forest restoration (Mori), biomass energy (Bio), patient long-term planting (Tane), community-owned digital infrastructure (Deta), EV charging and energy sovereignty (Denki), open knowledge and documentation (Akari), and disciplined funding-gate governance (Gate).